Government or Legal Document

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	When and where was this document created?
	What branch of government or authority created this document?
	Who wrote the document and what authority does that person or institution have?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	Who is the intended audience for this document?
	What kind of document is it? Legislation, verdict, treaty, proclamation, or something else? How was it distributed?
	What's the historical context of this document? What is the background or reason for it?
	Was the creation of this document an unusual event, or something done regularly?
	What is the subject of this document? What issue or issues does it address?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	Is this the first document of this type or on this issue?
	What does this document order, or what does it prohibit, if anything?
	Does this document have a particular perspective or bias?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	Does this document take sides with one or another political or social party or group with a certain point-of-view?
	What type of language is used in this document? Is it administrative or motivational? How do you think people reacted to it?
	Do you think this document is an effective one?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	Why was this document important to the people or institution who issued it, and why is important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from this document to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, historical change over time, etc.?
	Does comparing this document with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	How can you tie this document into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?